

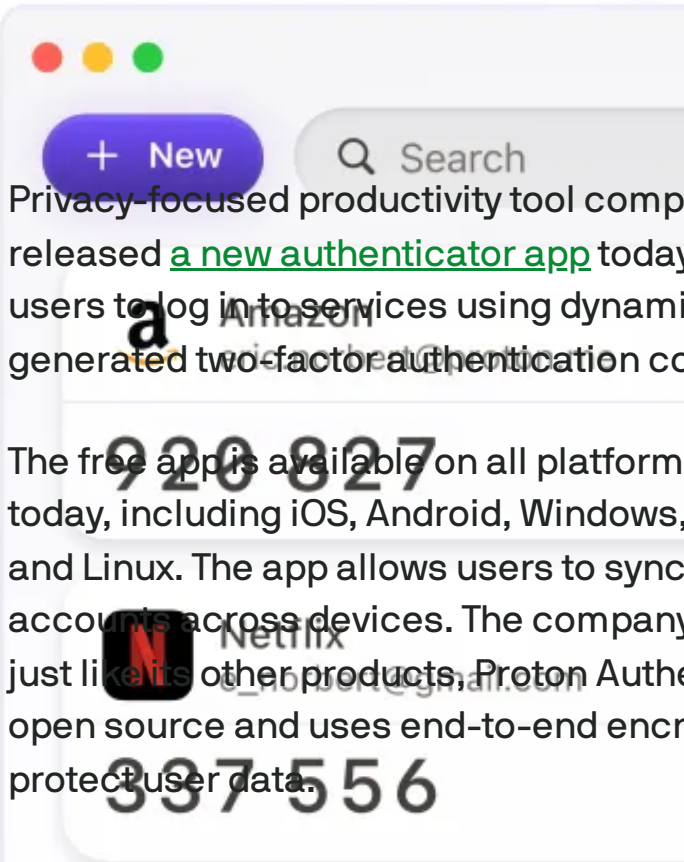
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## Proton releases a new app for two-factor authentication



Privacy-focused productivity tool company Proton released [a new authenticator app](#) today, allowing users to log into services using dynamically generated two-factor authentication codes.

The free app is available on all platforms starting today, including iOS, Android, Windows, macOS, and Linux. The app allows users to sync codes and accounts across devices. The company said that just like its other products, Proton Authenticator is open source and uses end-to-end encryption to protect user data.

Users can easily import login codes from other authentication apps, the company said. Plus, the app automatically backs up codes and also works without any internet connection.

|                       |  Proton Authenticator |  Google Authenticator |  Authy |  Microsoft Authenticator |  Duo |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Open source           | ✓                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                         | ✗                                                                                                           | ✗                                                                                       |
| Encrypted sync        | ✓                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                         | ✓                                                                                                           | ✓                                                                                       |
| No ads or tracking    | ✓                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                         | ✗                                                                                                           | ✓                                                                                       |
| Platform availability | Android<br>iOS<br>Windows<br>Mac<br>Linux                                                                | Android<br>iOS                                                                                           | Android<br>iOS                                                                            | Android<br>iOS                                                                                              | Android<br>iOS                                                                          |
| Direct export         | ✓                                                                                                        | ✓                                                                                                        | ✗                                                                                         | ✗                                                                                                           | ✗                                                                                       |
| Offline support       | ✓                                                                                                        | ✓                                                                                                        | ✓                                                                                         | ✓                                                                                                           | ✓                                                                                       |

IMAGE CREDITS: PROTON

“Two-factor authentication is essential for everyone – not just those who care about their privacy. Proton Authenticator is built for anyone

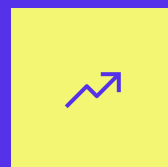
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who wants a secure, transparent, and convenient way to protect their accounts,” Eamonn Maguire, head of Account Security at Proton, said in a statement.

“We believe strong security should never come at the cost of your convenience or privacy. That’s why we’ve developed Proton Authenticator: to give users peace of mind that their 2FA codes are available wherever they need them, without relying on Google or Microsoft. We’re putting users firmly in control not only over their data, but the way they access their online accounts,” he added.

Two-factor authentication using an app provides users with an extra layer of security to prevent attackers from taking over accounts. While SMS-based two-factor authentication is another option, it is often vulnerable to SIM swapping attacks, in which attackers can intercept your calls and messages.

Proton is on a product-releasing spree. Earlier this week, the company launched [a privacy-focused AI chatbot named Lumo](#), which doesn’t keep any conversation records or use user data to train models.

- The uproar over Vogue’s AI-generated ad isn’t just about fashion
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

**TC**

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**Ivan Mehta**

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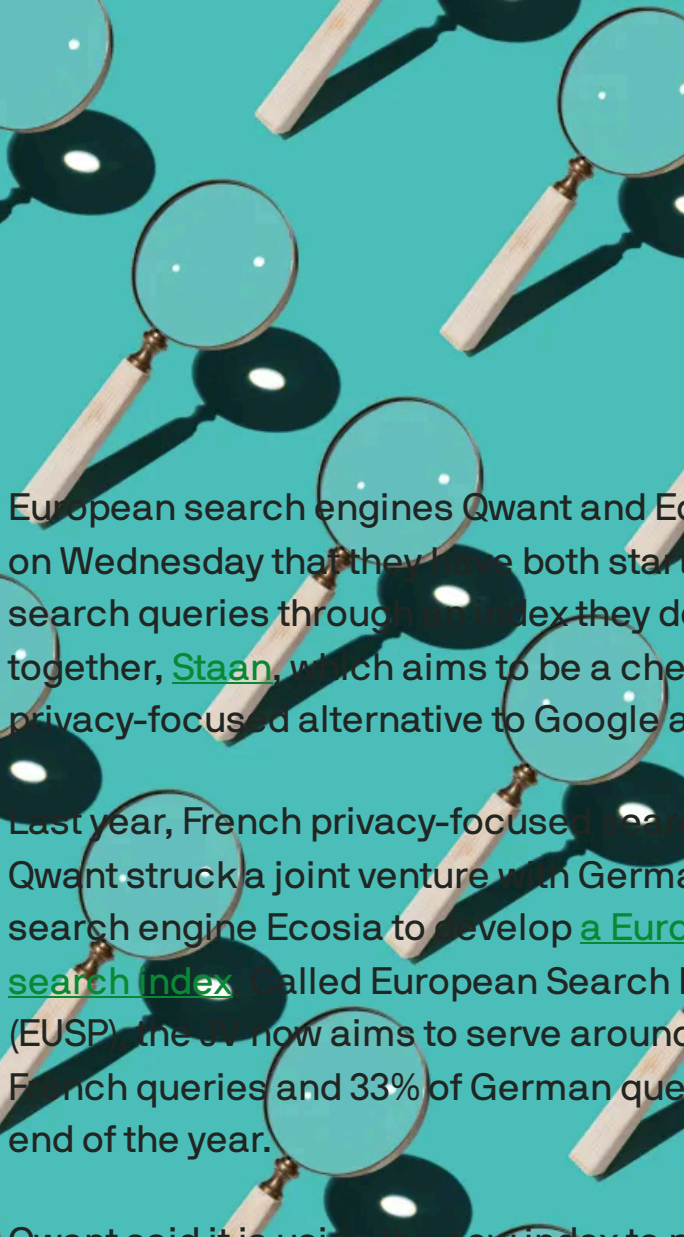
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Qwant and Ecosia debut  
Staan, a European  
search index that aims to  
take on Big Tech



European search engines Qwant and Ecosia said on Wednesday that they have both started serving search queries through an index they developed together, [Staan](#), which aims to be a cheaper, more privacy-focused alternative to Google and Bing.

Last year, French privacy-focused search engine Qwant struck a joint venture with German non-profit search engine Ecosia to develop [a European search index](#) called European Search Perspective (EUSP); the JV now aims to serve around 50% of French queries and 33% of German queries by the end of the year.

Qwant said it is using the new index to power some of its features, like AI summaries for search, and Ecosia has plans to add some AI features soon to its platform, too.

EUSP is also in talks with companies to spur the adoption of its index for enabling search within apps. Notably, it is targeting chatbots, presenting Staas as a cheaper alternative to Google and Bing.

“If you’re using ChatGPT or any other AI chatbot, they all do knowledge grounding with web search ... our index can power deep research and AI summary features. Google and Bing’s solutions are also pricey, and our index can offer power search features at a tenth of the cost,” Christian Kroll, CEO of Ecosia, told TechCrunch.

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EUSP, like [Proton](#), is pushing to develop a European tech stack that doesn't rely on technology from the U.S. or China.

"The timing could not be more urgent. The outcome of the 2024 U.S. election has reminded European policymakers and innovators just how exposed Europe remains when it comes to core digital infrastructure. Much of Europe's search, cloud, and AI layers are built on American Big Tech stacks, putting entire sectors — from journalism to climate tech — at the mercy of political or commercial agendas," the companies said in a statement.



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Kroll added that through this index, combined with European privacy laws, EUSP can offer a more privacy-friendly search solution as compared to its U.S. counterparts.

Topics: [AI](#) [Ecosia](#) [Qwant](#) [Search](#)

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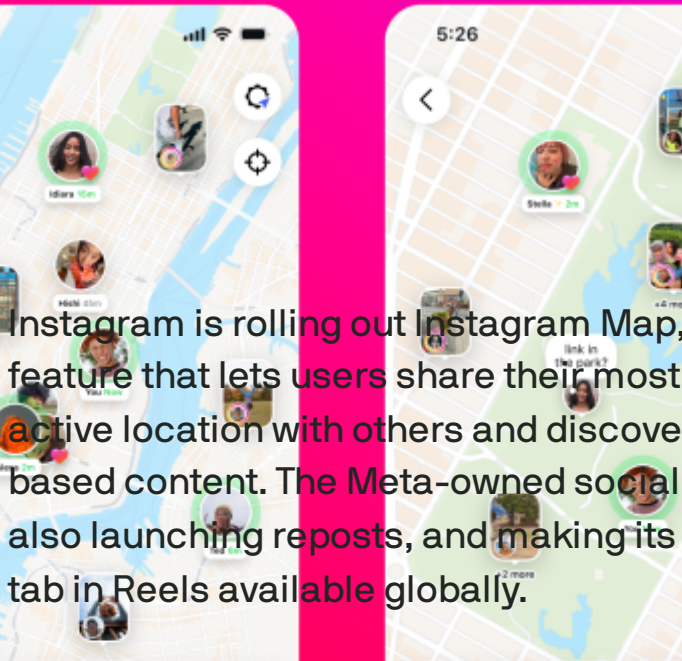
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APPS



# Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'





Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million monthly active users and remains one of the app’s core offerings.

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IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

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Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user’s location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn’t provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It’s worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple’s Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others

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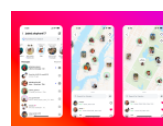
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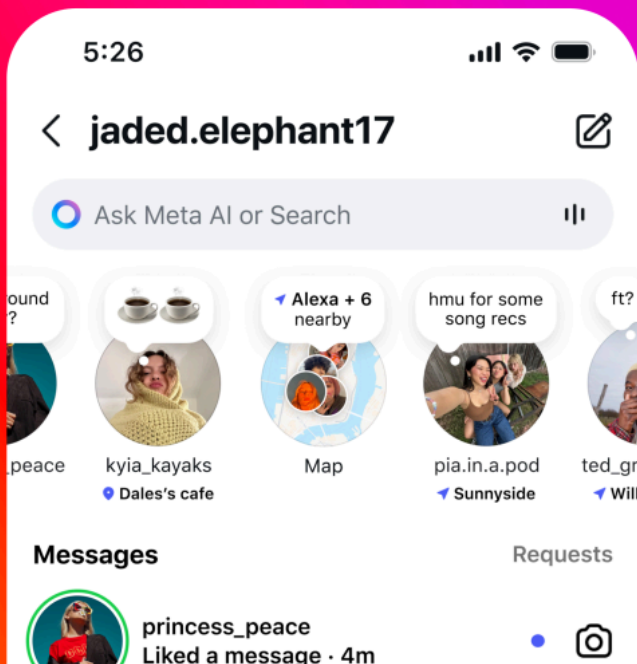


How to use Instagram Map and set your location-sharing preferences

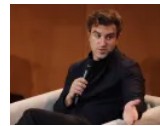
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Indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.



## AI



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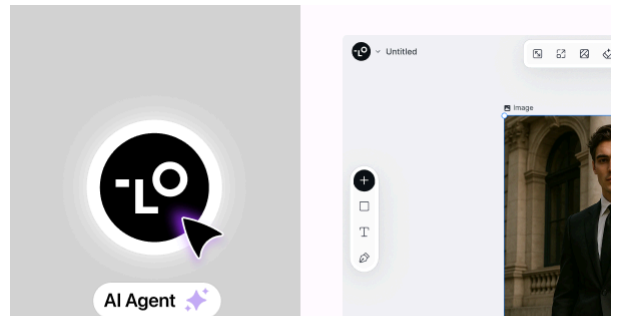
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The backlash against Duolingo going 'AI-first' didn't even matter

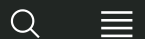
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location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or [“Notes,”](#) on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.



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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature last year.

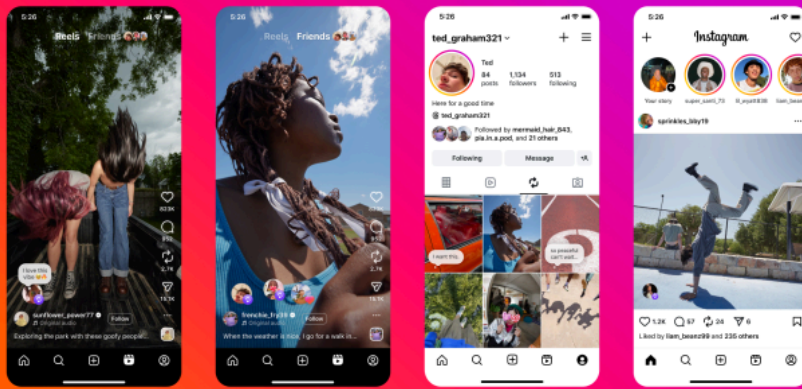


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

As for the new “Reposts” feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok’s book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular “retweet” function from Twitter (now X).

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**Design agents are here — Lovart launches the first end-to-end AI canvas for design**

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This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends’ feeds and will also be displayed in a new “Reposts” tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new “Friends” tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you’ve engaged with shown in the friends tab.

Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Instagram](#) [instagram map](#) [Snap Map](#)

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**Aisha Malik**

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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AI



# Google's AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google on Wednesday launched its AI coding agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its [public preview debut in May](#).

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

IMAGE CREDITS: JAGMEET SINGH / TECHCRUNCH

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Google [initially announced](#) Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it [available to beta testers](#) through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

"The trajectory of where we're going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be

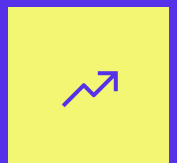
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around for the long haul,” she said.

With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an “introductory access” free plan capped at 15 individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules’ paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at \$19.99 and \$124.99 a month, and offer subscribers 5x and 20x higher limits, respectively.

Korevec noted that Jules’ packaging and pricing are based on “real usage” insights gathered over the past couple of months.

“The 60-task cap helped us study how developers use Jules and gave us the information we needed to design the new packaging,” she said. “The 15/day is designed to give people a sense of whether Jules will work for them on real project tasks.”

Google also updated Jules’ privacy policy to be more explicit about how it trains AI. If a repository is public, its data may be used for training, but if it is private, Korevec said that no data is sent.

“We got a little bit of feedback from users that it [the privacy policy] wasn’t as clear as we thought it was, and so most of it is just responding to that. We didn’t change anything about what we’re doing on the training side, but we changed the language,” Korevec said.

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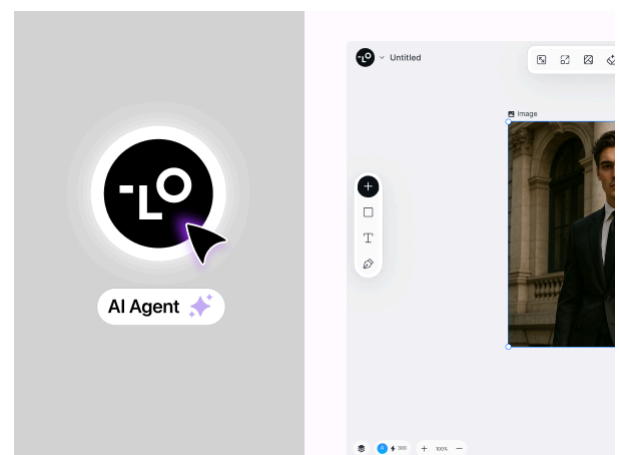
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During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements

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shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution, integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.

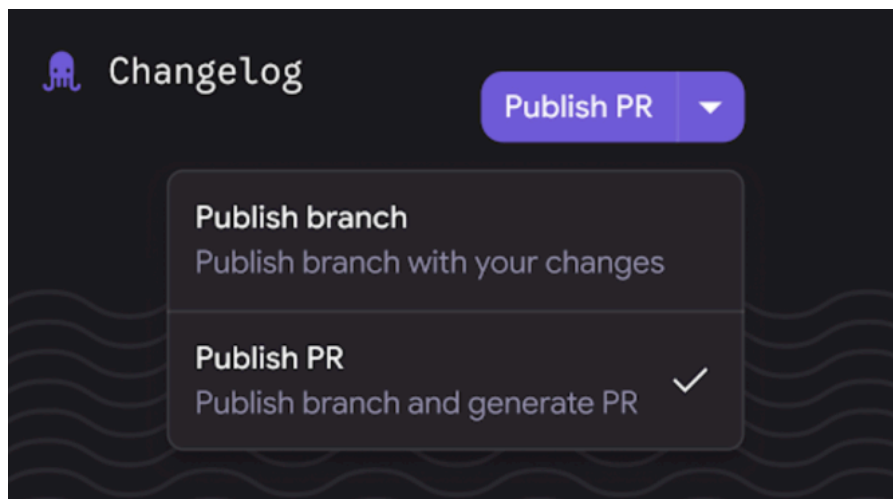


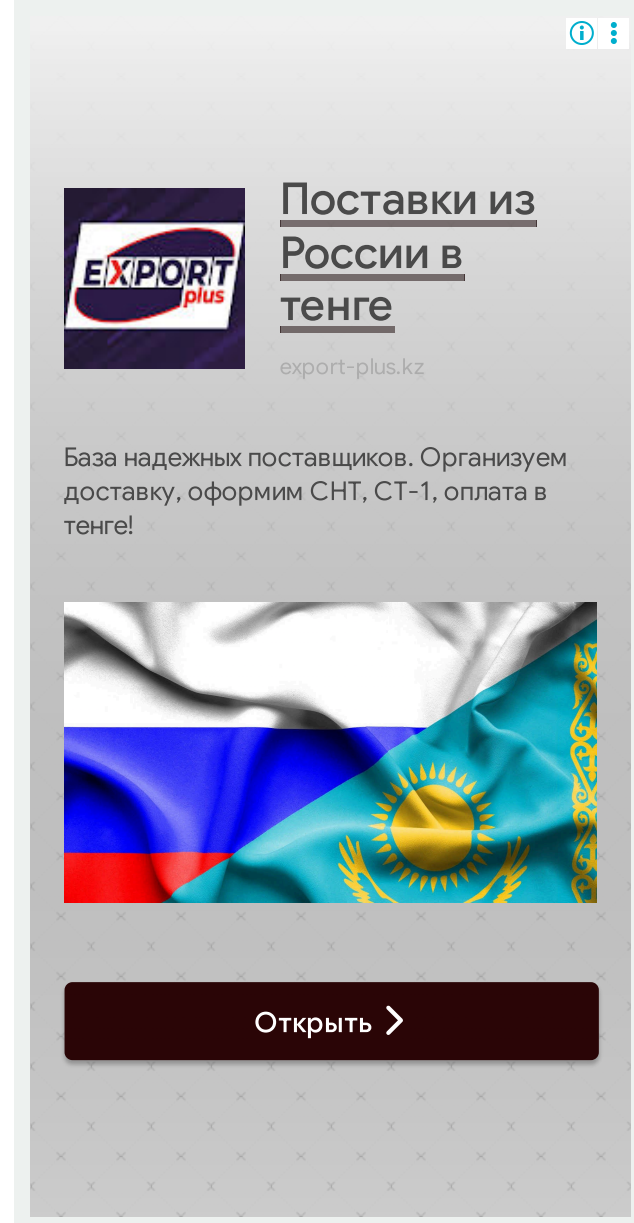
IMAGE CREDITS: JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

“Jules operates like an extra set of hands ... you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session,” Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to [open pull requests automatically](#) — just like it could open branches — and a feature called [Environment Snapshots](#) to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.





# From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules' development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider [SimilarWeb](#), reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules' user base and its top geographies.

Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

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Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs' team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

“Since it’s a big use case that we’re seeing emerging, we’re absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more,” she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects internally, and there is now a “big push” to use the tool on “a lot more projects” at the company.

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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